

The Art of Small Talk

What do we mean by small talk?

Small talk is the introduction to rapport building and real conversation. Without it, you rarely build relationships or get to more substantive dialogue. Often enough, people struggle with how to engage in small talk so we've created a framework and tips pulled largely from *The Art of Small Talk* by Debra Fine.

While there are many approaches to small talk, we suggest you start by focusing on:

1. Making yourself approachable,
2. Getting a conversation started,
3. Keeping a conversation going, and
4. Exiting a conversation.

How do you make yourself approachable?

Verbal	Non-Verbal
Introduce yourself	Open body language
Answer questions with more than one word	Be phone and gadget free
Be appropriately personal	Look up and make eye contact; Smile
Ask an appropriate question	Silent shyness can be mistaken for arrogance

Getting the conversation started:

- A relatively easy place to start is with who, what, when, and where questions that relate to the *location, situation, or occasion*. As mentioned earlier, you need to be appropriately personal.

What brought you to event?	Bring me up to date on...
How did you two meet?	What's been going on with work since...?
What got you interested in...?	How have your kids/colleagues been doing since...?
What keeps you busy outside of work?	What are you working on of late?

Keeping the conversation going

- Dig deeper: Finding something in their initial response to build upon. It's asking a probing question about their answer to learn more or keeping an ear open for a way you could be helpful to them, perhaps connecting them to something. If someone's answered your question with a one-word answer, it's following up with another question. For example, if you ask someone what's brought them to an event and they mention their work, ask them what they enjoy about that line of work.
- Be current: Know topics related to the location, situation, and occasion by keeping up with current events. These offer more points for connection and potentially common interests.
- Avoid conversation killers: Don't make up nicknames, ask about political views or religion, use tasteless humor or ask something too personal, too quickly, like if they're married or have kids.

Ending and exiting the conversation

- A simple way to end a conversation and exit is to say "I need" and then something that takes you somewhere else. For example, "I need to refill my coffee" OR "I promised a colleague I would meet them here, so I need to find them in a few minutes".
- Before leaving the conversation, help someone feel good about your interaction by mentioning something from the conversation that was interesting to you. For example, "I really enjoyed talking with you – your background is very interesting..." OR "Thank you for sharing your perspective on X, I've not heard that before...." Then follow this statement with the "I need" exiting tactic. You can also show your interest as you exit by saying you'd like to stay connected and exchanging business cards.
- You can also exit by introducing them to someone else. After that new conversation has begun, you can use the "I need" exiting tactic.

Resources

Online:

- Alumni = Career Services > Changing Companies, Functions, and Industries > Networking
- E/W = Careers > Market & Prepare Yourself > Prepare to Network

Books (Fisher Career Resource Center):

- *Never Eat Alone* – Keith Ferrazzi
- *How to Talk to Anyone: 92 Little Tricks for Big Success in Relationships* – Leil Lowndes
- *The Virtual Handshake: Opening Doors and Closing Deals Online* -- David Teten and Scott Allen

CareerCast (<https://www.chicagobooth.edu/careercast>)

- *Expand Your Success with Reciprocal Relationships* – Melissa Giovagnoli
- *Self-Promotion as a Career Strategy* – Nancy Ancowitz
- *Unpack the Fear of Connecting* – Gloria Petersen

Other

- Questions? Contact Career Services by email at boothworks@ChicagoBooth.edu or by calling 312-464-8677.